

What is puberty?

During puberty, females reach physical maturity and become capable of sexual reproduction. Puberty can be a challenging time as teens transform emotionally and physically.

Reaching maturity

Both males and females begin puberty when the brain produces gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH). This hormone triggers a wide range of physical and emotional changes that take place in stages, over several years, as the body develops. The process is different for everyone, but the key stages are common to all. It can be disorientating for teens, but talking to a trusted adult can help—after all, they once went through puberty, too.

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The menstrual cycle	36–37 >
Breasts	40–41 >

GOOD TO KNOW

Body confidence

Many teen girls feel self-conscious or embarrassed about their body during puberty, but try not to worry—it happens to everyone. It's natural, and it can be exciting.

What to expect

Girls begin puberty earlier than boys do, usually between 8 and 14 years old. During puberty, with so many transformations happening, it's not unusual for tweens and teens to feel as if their body and emotions are out of control. By learning about how the body works, a teen can feel better prepared for what will happen.



Increase in height
One of the first signs of puberty, this can sometimes happen in spurts.



Growing breasts
Small "breast buds" appear under the nipple, and the breasts grow gradually larger.



Pubic hair
The hair above and around the genitals gets thicker, darker, and coarser. By the end of puberty, this hair becomes curly.



Greasy hair
Most teens find their hair gets greasy, and that they have to wash it more regularly than they did before.



Gaining weight
Bones become heavier, and an extra layer of fat stores the energy needed to support growth.